gain a critical foothold during the early hours of D day; more than 100 died or were injured during the climb. Sixty-two of the survivors were there for the anniversary; with gray hair and faces weathered by age and life's experiences, they might have been elderly businessmen, and I suppose some of them were; but these were the boys, some of them just starting to shave at the time, who had given so much, had been so brave at the dawn of the assault. On that windswept point for which so much blood had been spilled, I tried to recount the story of their bravery. I think it was an emotional experience for all of us.

Afterward, Nancy and I entered a massive concrete pillbox from which, when dawn broke, German soldiers had first seen the five thousand ships of the invasion fleet. Then we flew to Omaha Beach, which was a heartbreaker—the sight of endless rows of white crosses and stars of David—more than nine thousand of them, and they represented only a portion of the casualties of D day.

President Mitterrand arrived and together we placed wreaths at a memorial, then I gave a speech containing quotes from a letter I'd received a few weeks before from a California woman, Lisa Zanatta Henn, whose father, Private Peter Zanatta, had not yet been twenty when he waded out of a bobbing landing craft in the first wave of invaders at Omaha Beach on June 6, 1944.

In her letter, Lisa said her father always dreamed of returning to Normandy. "Someday, Lis, I'll go back," he said, "I'll go back and I'll see it all again. I'll see the beach, the barricades and the graves. I'll put a flower on the graves of the guys I knew and on the grave of the unknown soldier—all the guys I fought with." But, she said, he had died of cancer a few years earlier without ever fulfilling his dream, and she had written to me to ask if she could attend the anniversary celebration as his representative.